throat and began ‘You may not be aware...’ only for Balfour to quickly interrupt him: ‘It’s all right George, we all know you have written a monumental work on Persia.’[124]

Bloody Retribution

With the various positions of authority that he occupied, his years of experience with India, Asia and Russia, and the sheer force of his personality, Curzon was a central figure within the British government in the post-war period. As viceroy, Curzon left his mark on India. As foreign secretary, he was determined to leave his mark on southern Asia. In fact, it seems that, after his ignominious departure from India in 1905, Curzon became even more resolute in the opinions formulated during this first stage of his career. Following his return to England, Curzon was decidedly out of favour in Whitehall, and it would be another ten years before he would finally get back into a position of power within government. His outburst in 1907 against the Anglo-Russian Convention demonstrates how he had lost none of his zeal when it came to Britain’s foreign affairs.[125] Yet between 1905 and 1917 he was to be largely frustrated in his ambitions, complaining to an acquaintance: ‘As one who was at the Foreign Office for three years, who served in India for seven, and who knows personally almost every country in Europe and Asia, I ought surely to be of greater use that I am now permitted to be.’[126] This period of political marginalisation would mean that when Curzon finally regained some authority in 1918 he would be sure to make it count. Driven by ambition and a redoubtable confidence in his personal knowledge and analytical abilities, Curzon would brook no opposition to his policies in Persia and elsewhere, even if the advice from others was actually sound.

As well as being of interest for the pivotal role he played in Britain’s foreign policy in the period after the First World War, Curzon also personified the concept of a Great Game mentality. He carried the thoughts and opinions which he had formulated in his early years of travel and his time as viceroy with him into the Foreign Office. This meant that this Great Game mentality was able to exert an influence over the direction of